

TEST PROCESS

The base system used for testing the software was a Celeron 433 with 64 MB RAM with an Intel i740 display card and Aureal Vortex 2 soundcard. The settings in the system were kept constant for all the software. We examined both categories of audio editing software—Wave editing software and MIDI sequencers. Products in both categories were tested for features, ease of use, performance and value.

While testing the products we looked for features such as multiple soundcard support, ability to rip CDs and integrated CD burning clients, real-time tempo

adjustment and audio enhancements. For testing MIDI software, we checked if the software allowed real-time effects and hardware support wherein you could plug in external MIDI controller devices such as synthesisers and keyboards.

Ease of use is another aspect that we checked. Software that allows easy cutting and pasting of parts of files across channels makes editing a lot easier. If it lets you add effects and change parameters such as the track's pitch, tempo, patch (or instrument) values, it contributes to ease of use. Software that offer a concise inter-

face were given extra points. Another point we noted was the online and integrated help.

Under performance we checked for the software's ability to handle large audio tracks and also work in high-quality modes that would enable the overall output of the track to be of controllable and high quality. Finally, we weighed the features and the performance of the various software against their price. Software that were more feature packed and easier to learn and use were awarded more points in this category.

song is to be encoded in Wave file format, it is broken down into small chunks of data that are 'sampled' and processed, wherein a number of bits are used to store the value of the audio wave at that point in time.

Hence, the waveform is sampled many times a second and encoded. CD quality Wave files are, for example, stored using 16-bit samples that are taken 44,100 times per second (or 44.1 KHz). Lower the sampling rate and bit depth, lower is the quality of the audio and smaller is the file. This form of audio encoding does not undergo any form of compression, resulting in huge file sizes.

Features

The presence of features such as multiple soundcard support, ability to rip CDs and CD burning, real time tempo adjustment and audio enhancements such as equalizer are what set a good sound editing application apart from the run of the mill.

It's a good feature if the software supports many file formats, which means you can import sound files in different formats and also export the file in the format you prefer.

As far as features are concerned, **Sound Forge 5** emerges at the top with its extensive set of features and integrated options for CD ripping and burning. Also interesting is its high encoding quality support and the presets for working with your audio. It has features such as Acoustic Mirroring and Wave Hammer.

The Acoustic Mirror option allows you to simulate different real-life acoustic environments such as water pipe, concert hall, and others. You get to play around with more than 30 audio effects and around 200 presets. Encoding audio in RealMedia format for broadcast over the Internet is possible here. In fact, you get support for audio encoding up to 92 KHz.

Cool Edit 2000 offers you something quite close to what professionals use. It allows you to record your own music and change and modify



Cooledit 2000: Quite feature-rich

its parameters the way you want. For instance, you can add effects such as reverb, flange, echo, etc. This can help you incorporate real-life sound effects and simulate acoustics such as that of a church or in a tunnel. Furthermore, you can amplify sound, add or remove noise or stretch it. You can also change the format of the song file to a plethora of output audio formats—RealMedia, AIF, MP3, etc.

Wavelab too offers interesting features such as 3D Frequency Analysis and Audio Signal Generator. This audio editor includes very interesting plugins and features support for DVD-quality encoding. You can apply effects such as Stereo Echo and even preview it while the file is playing. You can apply hi-fi chorus to a file or boost the bass with the equaliser. It also has some good editing tools such as pitch correction, harmonisation, stretch and pitch shift.

Ease of use

One should feel comfortable while using any software. The same goes for audio editing software, be it Wave or MIDI. The interface should be easy to work with and executing tasks should be simple. A software that allows easy cutting and pasting of parts of files across channels makes editing a lot easier and work can be completed faster. If the software lets you add effects and literally 'twist' a file in no time, it contributes to



More Info on
the test process and the
products tested,
Software related to sound
editing, check out
Mindware

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